Mending Fences

As 1997 drew to a close, Ratan treaded on thin ice. If the Assam police had pressed charges under non-bailable provisions, the senior functionaries of Tata Tea may have had more reasons to worry. The Gauhati High Court had not granted their officials bail and the Supreme Court had not entertained their appeal for anticipatory bail.

Some of the company's functionaries were arrested and charged. Krishna Kumar too was subjected to extensive questioning. Many of the Tata Tea employees lived in fear. Despite the group's efforts, its reputation had been adversely affected both within and outside the country.

As the situation was defying resolution, Ratan moved to engage the political leadership with the hope that it would make a difference. He knew that mending fences with Mahanta was perhaps the only viable solution. Their last meeting in September, though cordial, had not yielded any meaningful outcome. The issue of locating Gogoi had further embittered relations. 'It was a prosecution by the Assamese government at that time,' said Ratan in an interview. Given this situation, he adopted his preferred approach of talking to resolve issues.

There were two very influential persons that Ratan reached out to for help—Jyoti Basu and Bhishma Narain Singh. Bhishma Narain Singh, former governor of Assam, was a popular and a sagacious politician who had served in the Union Cabinet. During his governorship, he had nurtured close relations with the political leaders in Assam, especially Mahanta. They had become personal friends during the political discussions that led to the Assam Accord in 1985.

If these heavyweights could be persuaded to weigh in to dissolve the distrust that existed between the Tata Group and the Assam government, it could make all the difference. Both expressed their willingness to help broker peace.

Basu took the extraordinary step of first writing to Mahanta, enclosing Tata Tea's press release 'promising support to the Assam Government'. He followed this up with a private meeting with Mahanta when he visited Assam in the end of October. During the meeting, Basu 'impressed upon' Mahanta the importance of finding a solution to the vexing problem.

During the discussions, Mahanta was quoted as telling Basu that his government was investigating if the welfare projects of the Tatas in the state